

RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE
IN JUDAISM

TENTH INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE
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THURSDAY, JULY 4th, 1957

LECTURE in the Amsterdam University BARUCH SPINOZA—HIS RELIGIOUS IMPORTANCE FOR THE JEW OF TODAY

by PROFESSOR LEON ROTH

Chairman: M. MARCEL GREILSAMMER (France)

Prayer: RABBI J. SOETENDORP (Holland)

M. GREILSAMMER expressed his deep regret that Rabbi M. C. Weiler, who had been asked to preside that evening, was unable to be at the Conference. In opening this Tenth International Conference, we should all enjoy being together in this old and glorious city of Amsterdam, which was not only the main city of a courageous and industrious country, but also had been for years a centre of Jewish population, Jewish worship and Jewish knowledge. He expressed deep gratitude to the Liberaal Joodse Gemeente of Amsterdam for its kind hospitality, and particularly to Dr. Klopfer and Mr. Jacobi, and the members of the Council for the difficult task of organising the present Conference.

He voiced his regret that Dr. Baeck would no more grace their meetings, but rejoiced that Miss Montagu was still at the head of the World Union, with the same energy and wisdom. He wished to offer to her the deep affection and respect of all the delegates.

The Conference would provide lectures by outstanding leaders, but in the private sessions and discussions, they had the responsibility of considering grave problems concerning the organisation and future of the World Union. It was his earnest hope that the delegates from the Progressive Congregations of the world would succeed in strengthening the World Union, in order that it might become not a mere federation of Constituents, but a real leading spiritual Movement playing an active role in the Jewish religious world.

MR. ROBERT LEVISSON, son of the founder of the Liberal Jewish Movement in the Netherlands welcomed the delegates. Many years have passed since the World Union for Progressive Judaism last chose Holland as the country in which to hold its convention. I was a youngster of 18 years when you first gathered here. Many of the participants of 1932 are no longer amongst us.

BARUCH SPINOZA
HIS RELIGIOUS IMPORTANCE FOR THE JEW
OF TO-DAY

BY

Professor LEON ROTH
Officier d'Académie, M.A. D.Phil, F.B.A. (Gt. Britain)

I

Before I come to my theme it may be well to remind ourselves of a few facts of literary history.

Spinoza was born in Amsterdam some ten months after this great and famous University was inaugurated, on 24th November, 1632, and died at the Hague on 21st February, 1677. His fame rests principally on two books, the *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus* published anonymously in 1670 and the *Ethica* published in 1677 by his friends as a part of his *Opera Posthuma*. Of these two books it was the former, the *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus*, which in its time created the stir. The *Ethica* waited for notice a full hundred years.

Yet, once noticed, the *Ethica* came into its own; the *Tractatus* passed into history. The *Tractatus* belongs to time, the *Ethica* to eternity; and it is this distinction, the distinction between the things of time and the things of eternity, so strikingly exemplified in the history of Spinoza's own work, which is the main lesson that men of religion today can derive from the study of Spinoza.

II

We are assembled this evening in order to learn for our present need from a thinker of the seventeenth century born and bred in this city of Amsterdam; and the first question we should ask ourselves is why it should be just *this* city, *this* people, *this* country and its institutions, which made his life, and thinking, possible. And not his life alone. Seventeenth century Holland first set the example followed so nobly by Holland of the twentieth century of offering

refuge and peace to the wanderer and homeless. I read to you a few sentences from a letter of one of them written in May, 1631:

"I walk every day among the thronging crowds as freely and quietly as you could in your private park . . . What other country could one find in the whole world where one can enjoy such complete liberty, and sleep with such a sense of security; where there are armed forces always on the watch to guard us; where poisonings and treacheries and calumnies are less known?"

It is René Descartes who is writing, in this very city of Amsterdam, a year before Spinoza was born; and he praises the industry and prosperity of its inhabitants, its public order and private amenities, its allowing everyone to pursue his own affairs without interference. Spinoza, writing nearly forty years later, sees deeper. He sees that all these qualities and characteristics are inter-related; and he boldly proclaims them to be the direct consequence of Holland's declared policy of freedom:

"It is the fruit of this freedom (he writes) which the city of Amsterdam reaps in its own great prosperity and in the admiration of all other peoples. For in this most flourishing state, and most splendid city, men of every nation and religion live together in the greatest harmony . . . Religion and sect is considered of no importance. It has no effect upon the judges in gaining or losing a cause; and there is no sect so despised that its followers, provided that they harm no one, give every man his due, and live uprightly, are deprived of the protection of the magisterial authority."

This passage, from the xxth chapter of the *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus*, clinches the argument of the whole book. The Treatise—as I propose to call it for short—is a reasoned plea (possibly the first, certainly one of the most striking, in modern literature) for *complete* freedom of thought and expression (even John Locke's notable Letters on Toleration admit serious restrictions). The Treatise asserts *not* that the granting of this complete freedom by governments is *possible* but that it is *essential*. Freedom can not only be conceded *without harm* to the community. The community *suffers harm if deprived* of it. Freedom is the first condition both of social health and of private well-being. It is the pre-requisite of civilized living. Without it society becomes rotten, government becomes corrupt, the citizen a mindless automaton.

This lesson has been re-discovered by our generation in the course of the strains and stresses of our own day. When we read such sentences as these (chap. xx): "The ultimate aim of the state is not to tyrannize, or hold men in by fear and make them dependent, but on the contrary to free every man from fear that he may live in all possible security; that is to say, that he may retain in its fulness the natural right to exist and act without harming himself and others. No, I say, the object of the state is not to change men from rational beings into beasts or puppets but, on the contrary, to help their minds and bodies to perform in safety their proper functions, and they themselves to use their reason freely and not struggle against others in hatred, anger or deceit or be stirred against one another in enmity. In very fact, therefore, the true aim of the state is liberty"—when we read sentences such as these, we rub our eyes and ask whether they were not written yesterday. The general conclusion of the Treatise is thus startlingly fresh. What is so puzzling about it is the way it is reached. Open the Treatise, and you may think that, in its first half at least, you have before you a Biblical scholar's note book written on the interleavings of a volume of sermons. Now it is just this seemingly irrelevant material which is of importance to our immediate subject.

III

For I am asked to discuss with you what the religious Jew of today can learn from Spinoza. By that I understand, not without relief, that you do not wish to hear a disquisition on Spinoza's metaphysics, or on Spinoza's sources, or on the rightness or wrongness of the ban pronounced on Spinoza by the Jewish authorities in Amsterdam three centuries ago. These matters are all interesting and important, and there yet remains on them much to be said. But 'What the religious Jew of today can learn from Spinoza' is a different theme altogether; and in attempting it, I suggest that we start from—I do *not* say, *rest in*—the seeming irrelevancies of Spinoza's Treatise, for it is among them that we find an account both of religion in general and of Judaism.

Of course the irrelevances are not really irrelevant. One of the greatest freedoms, freedom of worship, is not unconnected with freedom of expression, and freedom of expression with freedom of belief; and belief has something to do with religion, and religion (dare I say it?) with Judaism, and a primary source, and stimulus,

for the understanding both of religion and of Judaism may not unreasonably be seen in the Bible. So the Treatise, although its object is the demonstration of a principle of politics, spends much time in discussing the Bible.

For Spinoza, and indeed his whole generation, especially in Holland (then, as now, pre-eminent in Biblical studies) not only knew the Bible well; they took it seriously; much as right down to our own day men took the Greek and Latin classics seriously. In the same way our Treatise uses the Bible as a storehouse of experience, and as a guide in matters of religion and of moral and social thinking.

Taking the Bible in our hands then, and accepting it, as Spinoza insists, in its own light and at its own valuation, what do we find? Well, *Spinoza* finds a lot of unexpected things. He finds, for example, that—for the Bible—belief in God does not depend on miracle (rather, belief in miracle on belief in God). He finds that—according to the Bible—prophecy was not unique to the Jews. He finds that the pre-eminence of the Jewish prophets was not intellectual but moral, and that their teaching had nothing to do with philosophical or scientific truths. He finds that religion—for the Bible—lies not in knowledge but in obedience, obedience to simple moral rules. He even finds—remember that he is writing in the seventeenth century—that (for the Bible) opinion on matters of religious belief can not only vary (and be allowed to vary) from one man to another, but also in the mind of one and the same man, without the essentials of religion being affected. All this, we read in the Treatise, is the clear doctrine of the Bible; and therefore—according to the Bible—creeds and catechisms, that is, metaphysical formulations of belief, have no place in state legislation. The state can only require its citizens to act morally. It cannot require them to think logically. It can impose upon them rules of conduct. It cannot impose upon them articles of belief. So far as the Bible is concerned, everybody can think what he likes and say what he thinks, provided that he acts justly and is kind to his fellow-men. That is religion, the religion of the Bible, says the Treatise. The rest is metaphysics and a man's private affair.

It is not to my purpose here to discuss the validity of these positions. Paradoxical as some of them may appear to be, I fancy myself that Spinoza is right; right, that is, in affirming that these are in fact the fundamental positions of the Bible. But it is obvious

that the Bible voices other attitudes as well, attitudes not of tolerance but of intolerance. Spinoza is constrained therefore to enquire into the nature and source of these too.

If only Spinoza had lived in the nineteenth century, his path would have been easier; but in the seventeenth century the historical school was yet to be. Or again, if only he had read a book then in process of composition at Christ's College, Cambridge, the *De Legibus Hebraeorum* of John Spencer, he might have gone back to the chapters of Maimonides' Guide for the Perplexed which in principle give the required key and which Spencer developed so fruitfully. But the anthropological approach would in any case have been alien to Spinoza's mathematical mind. He seems too, at the time of his writing the Treatise, to have been still sore at his treatment by the Synagogue; and, according to a conjecture of one of the greatest of modern students of Spinoza and a lover both of Holland and of Jewry, the lamented Dr. Carl Gebhardt, Spinoza probably put into the Treatise part of the earlier Apology which he is said to have prepared when called upon in 1656 to defend himself before the Synagogue authorities. But be that as it may, and rightly or wrongly, Spinoza in the Treatise blamed all the intolerance and cruelty of the Bible on the Jews. Broadly speaking, he assigns all the fine things of the Bible to what he calls Universal Religion, all the unpleasant things to what he calls the Hebrew 'Respublica' (that is, Commonwealth) as it is based on the Mosaic code which is tacitly equated by him with Judaism.

We are thus brought to the consideration of Judaism, or rather, of Spinoza's account of it.

IV

Spinoza's account of Judaism is contained principally in his chapters on the Vocation of the Hebrews (iii), the Ceremonial Law (v), and the Hebrew Theocracy (xvii). There is much besides this in the Treatise of interest for the student of Judaism. I should mention in particular his chapters on Prophecy and the Prophets (i, ii), and his remarks on the Interpretation of Scripture (vii) and its Sacredness (xii) and Simplicity (xiii). These chapters touch the very quick of the problem of authority which is one of the great water-sheds of theological theory. But the chapters I have indicated (on the vocation of the Hebrews, the ceremonial law and the Hebrew theocracy) deal with the concrete characteristics of Judaism as a separate entity and should therefore engage our special attention.

Briefly—and I remind you yet again that Spinoza is reporting what he says he finds in the Bible—the 'vocation' (that is, the 'call') of the Hebrews was political only. Its end, he says (and I quote his own words) was the 'formation of a society with fixed laws; the occupation of a strip of territory; and the concentration of all forces as it were into one body, that is, the body of the society.' The excellence of the Hebrews, he says, lay in their political organisation alone. Their laws were indeed remarkable; but these laws, including the laws of their religion, were intended only to produce obedience to the social order and to promote its conservation. The Mosaic Code was given to and for the Hebrews alone. Its ceremonies, like the inducements it offers to obedience, were local and temporal only. They looked solely to the preservation of the Hebrew community. The religion which is Judaism is thus (according to this view) the cement which bound together the Mosaic state; and its value, a value which is derivative and adventitious, not intrinsic, lay in its use for the preservation of that state: it was an instrument to aid its survival. It was, as it were, the cocoon spun by the state out of the juices of its own body for the purpose of its own protection.

Spinoza follows the conventional (and to my mind, unfortunate and misleading) view that there are to be distinguished in it the two parts of ceremony and morality. The ceremonial consisted in certain customs and habits of behaviour; and with the political disappearance of the community in which it inhered, its reason for existence disappeared. The moral, summed up in the principles of love and kindness and justice, was also intended to strengthen the society; but owing to the intuition of the Prophets it became clear that what was salutary for this one society was salutary for all societies, and thus the ideals of love and justice, because they transcended the bounds of the Hebraic state, survived the destruction of that state and became the foundation of the religion of mankind. This religion is non-political in the sense that it is not confined to any one nation or to any one country. It knows no monopolies, that is, no chosen people and no promised land. It rejects the very idea of credal sectarianism; but since men differ in their opinions (as Spinoza remarks) as much as they do in their faces, the uniformity it requires is not of creed but of moral action.

We are here (on Biblical grounds) at the general conclusion of the Treatise as a whole. So far as Spinoza's particular account of Judaism is concerned, it will be noted that in his view Judaism

is universalist by accident and never so (apparently) for Jews. In essence it is, in the narrow sense, political and (in Spinoza's view) narrowly and savagely political; and those who love to quote his remark on the *possibility* of the re-emergence of the Hebraic state would do well to ponder the reasons he gives in a later passage for its *inadvisability*. Judaism for Spinoza is a tribal habit of life, isolationist and misanthropic, a device for group survival.

V

And we survive. But by virtue of what? On Spinoza's principles it would seem we have no right to. The cement of a political community would naturally be expected to disappear with the disappearance of that community. In *this* case, however, the political community disappeared but the cement remained, itself to create a community of a different kind altogether. But we may leave this general puzzle and ask whether, on Spinoza's own express ground, the ground of the Bible, we need accept Spinoza's theory at all.

An enquiry of this nature is the proper task of our theologians and I hesitate to intrude into their sphere. But certain points leap to the eye. Does Spinoza, as he deals with the evidence from the Bible, take into account all of it, or the most significant part of it, or even (quantitatively) most of it? For example, when he speaks of the 'call' of the Jewish people, he speaks of it as a bare political fact. He says nothing of its moral end. But according to the Bible which Spinoza says he is expounding, this moral end is of the very essence of the call: without it the call is no call at all. The very first charter of Jewry—according to the Bible—makes Jewry dependent on Judaism, almost a 'function' of Judaism. 'For I have known him', God is represented as saying to Abraham long before the seed of Abraham grew into the people in which all the nations of the earth are to be blessed, 'For I have known him *to the end that* he may command his children and his household after him, that they may keep the way of God, to do justice and judgment.' For a student of the Bible this is plain enough; and I need hardly remind students of later Judaism that this verse is constantly used in this 'charter' sense by the great systematiser and shaper of our own Judaism, Moses Maimonides. In the Bible itself the conception is repeated constantly, and in various forms, on other—Biblically speaking—crucial occasions.

Yet of all this I find nothing in Spinoza. Nor do I find the prophetic conception of Witness; nor the no less striking and prominent doctrine of the Remnant; nor the constant Biblical emphasis that the fulfilment of the promises is dependent on the fulfilment of the conditions, the *moral* conditions, under which the promises were given; nor the constant calling of the people back to the primary decencies of moral living. Biblical Judaism is always *ahead of* the Jewish people, always *in advance of* them, always telling them in no uncertain fashion what they should be doing and what they should not be doing. "They may cry, We, Israel, know thee; but Israel hath cast off what is good." "God hath a controversy with the inhabitants of the land, because there is no truth, nor mercy, nor knowledge of God in the land; there is naught but swearing and breaking faith and killing and stealing." That is the authentic voice of Judaism, yet it is not saying what on Spinoza's theory one would have expected it to say. On Spinoza's theory one would have expected the 'comforting words' of the prophets stigmatised in the Bible as *false*, what we recognise today as the propagandists bolstering up a political regime or giving 'pep' to the morale of its so-called citizens. Spinoza is impressed, and rightly impressed, with the universality of the prophetic teaching. He ignores the moral obligation and the moral function which that very teaching imposed on the Jewish people. Take that away, and (as Amos said) the Jews are just such another wandering tribe as the Ethiopians and the Philistines.

These great omissions and evasions culminate in Spinoza's treatment of the Biblical Covenant. The Covenant is not for the Bible, a *political fact*, as Spinoza would seem to hold, but a *religious act*. This act constituted Jewry as a peculiar people, it created the Jewish people in the Biblical sense. Whether the act is one of bare acceptance on our part, or something more, I leave to the determination of the theologians. But we should note that there is here (as in any other covenant) another side, a partner, a co-signatory, who in *this* covenant is *all-important*; for—according to the Bible and in the formulation of the prayer-book—he 'chose us out of all the nations and gave us his law', *thereby*—if I may animadvert to the problem of the survival of Jewry—'planting in our midst everlasting life.'

I suggest then that Spinoza has misread his evidence. According to the Bible, the way of life (which is the way of God) created

the nation, not the nation the way of life. Judaism is not the product of any community for the reason that it seeks to produce a community. It was never offered as the cement of the Mosaic Commonwealth because that Commonwealth was planned as its realisation. Judaism is the idea behind it, not its fruit. It is its programme rather than its present constitution. It is not a fact but a force. As the Rabbis put it in their quaint but arresting way, the Torah—Judaism—was created a thousand generations before the world; and I may perhaps be allowed to add the sobering thought that, according to the Bible, the world was created before the Jews.

VI

But we must press on to the deeper issues. We are met to discuss religion, not politics or sociology; and if Spinoza really joins hands with Durkheim and Ahad HaAm, so much the worse for him. But does he? Let us enquire a little further.

In the Treatise Spinoza is arguing to a thesis. As its title, *Tractatus Theologico-Politicus*, clearly indicates, he is not proposing to deal with religion as such or politics as such but with their inter-working and combination. He is treating religion from the point of view of government and legislation; and from the point of view of government and legislation, feeling and opinion and the varying creeds and the differing philosophies can rightly be considered irrelevant. What men do is what matters to government, and what men do can be made subject to control. Religion then, so far as government is concerned, can be treated as a matter of public morals. As he says in his praise of the city of Amsterdam I have already quoted:

“Religion and sect is considered of no importance. It has no effect before the judges in gaining or losing a cause; and there is no sect so despised that its followers, provided that they harm no one, gives every man his due, and live uprightly, are deprived of the protection of the magisterial authority.”

But the magistrate's court is not everything. Indeed, I suppose that most of us have not even been inside one. For government and legislation are not the only, and they are not the determining, factors in life, and public order is not the only consideration. These are only the external framework of life, and even so, only from a limited point of view. The flavour and savour of life as it is lived lies just in the feelings and emotions and opinions and creeds which

are irrelevant to public order and which do not come up in the courts at all. This is ignored in the Treatise, and (in view of its special and limited purpose) rightly. But it cannot be ignored in any comprehensive view of life. And Spinoza does offer a comprehensive view of life, not however in the Treatise but in the Ethics.

And so we can appeal from Spinoza to Spinoza. Does the religion of the Treatise, the religion of charity and good deeds, tally with the religion of the Ethics? It may be held perhaps to correspond to the religion of the *Fourth* Book of the Ethics which describes the life of the ‘Free Man’ living in accordance with the rule of right reason. But what of the *Fifth* Book with its mysterious and suggestive proportions, so calmly enunciated, so elegantly demonstrated, about the eternity of the mind, and the love of man for God and the love of God for man, propositions which would seem to embrace most of what is meant by religion to the ordinary religious man. Our destiny, our highest hopes, our dependence, our independence, our present beauty, our final salvation—what are these but the great themes of religion as described, or as felt, by all. In the words of Spinoza himself: ‘We feel and experience that we are eternal’; or, more positively: ‘Man could not exist or be conceived unless he had the power to grasp the eternal and infinite essence of God.’ If *this* is religion (and so it would seem), then in religion lies the source, and the support, and indeed the very fruition, of that very freedom the fostering of which, according to the Treatise, is the end and aim of the political organisation of society.

As we pass then from the one of Spinoza's two great books to the other, we find an expansion and supplementation of values which is almost a reversal. Politics and the political view are not enough. The magistrates' courts are not the whole of life. Man is not only a political animal. The time and place, the community and its organisation, of the Treatise are cradled in the eternity of the Ethics.

Eternity as expounded by Spinoza is an idea of positive quality. It is contrasted specifically with quantitative endlessness. It is the completion of existence, reality in its fulness. It is in no sense a ‘never-never land’. It is rather, if I may so phrase it, an ‘ever-ever land’—the ‘absolute affirmation of existence’, the ‘infinite enjoyment of being’, says Spinoza (Eth. I, 8 sch., Ep. XII)—a land which is not there but here, not hereafter but now, a land which, ever-present, beckons us on, and which our highest striving is to go over to and

inhabit. It is the Kingdom of Heaven which is within us; and it is notable that Spinoza, when he comes to speak of its central point, the unity of the love of God for man and the love of man for God, and the 'stillness of mind', the *acquiescentia in se ipso*, which is engendered in those who attain it, can think only of the Biblical 'Glory' in order to express and illustrate the salvation, the blessedness, the 'liberty', so attained. The Bible, he seems to agree, contains more than the political life. Religion means more than the state.

It means more than the state and it is stronger than the state; as indeed is suggested by recent experience. Only religion has in our day and before our eyes shown the strength to stand up to the great arrogance of our time, the arrogance of the state. Religion too is arrogant. Like the God of the Bible, jealous and terrible as well as full of mercy and love, it makes its demands, presents its claims, from above. But the arrogance of politics enslaves our humanity. The arrogance of religion creates it and gives it shape. The power of the one crushes and destroys; the authority of the other raises up. It dwells in the high and holy place, but with him also that is of a contrite and humble heart, to give new life to the spirit and to proclaim liberty to the captives and to open the doors of the various prisons invented by the ingenuity of our politicians for our bodies and souls alike.

Thus I suggest to you that the religious Jew of today may well turn to the Ethics, and particularly to its Fifth Book, for one of the great needs of our lives (particularly within Jewry), a religious approach to religion. For the 'free man' of the Fourth Book of the Ethics, the highest product of the political life, ideal participant in the ideal republic of the supposedly autonomous rule of right reason—the Free Man *cannot become himself* unless, as is clearly indicated in the last sentence of the Fourth Book, he receives the support of the truths underlying, and expounded in, the Fifth. Humanism is not enough for the simple reason that man is more than narrowly human.

VII

The Fifth (and last) Book of the Ethics demonstrates in detail the contention of the famous autobiographical passage which opens the unfinished Treatise on the Emendation of the Intellect. In this

passage, as you will remember, Spinoza sets out from the futility of ordinary experience; and he describes how he came to see that it is only by love directed towards the infinite and eternal that we can rid ourselves of subjection to the pursuits of the fleeting and evanescent pseudo-goods of life: money, fame, desire. Ultimately, the way of right living and the way of right feeling and the way of right thinking are one and the same. Its practical side is the familiar one of detachment. But it is detachment of a special kind. It is detachment *through attachment*, attachment to the eternal and infinite object which can never alter and never disappoint, the one object which can arouse an emotion strong enough to master all other emotions.

For emotional life remains the truth of man: desire cannot be extinguished. But it can be diverted. Its object can be changed. Its 'proper' object can be found.

Spinoza's philosophy may thus be accounted as his discovery and exploration of the infinite and eternal. But he could not have set out on the quest if he had not in some fashion already known its end. 'Thou couldst not find me if thou hadst not known me.'

This pre-figuration, or pre-vision, or pre-adumbration, of the infinite and eternal is the first root of religion. We are men, not stones. We *start with* a sense of eternity; but a *sense* of eternity is not *the knowledge* of eternity, certainly not its full consciousness or its fruit. It is a *nisus*, a striving, a groping, which exists in us owing to the facts of our human, and of universal, nature. It is only slowly and with difficulty and through the exercise of conscious effort that we attain the clarity of the real. But the beginnings are in us from the start. 'We feel and experience that we are eternal.' 'It is no accident but arises out of the very nature of reason, that man's highest good should be common to all For it appertains to the very essence of the human mind to have an adequate knowledge of the eternal and infinite essence of God.'

VIII

Here too we may learn from Spinoza. Salvation is not cheap nor its attainment easy. At the outset of our enquiry we learned the negative lesson that politics is not enough and that the political approach to religion is inadequate. We then learned that moralism too is not enough. Religion includes morals but it is more than morals. We now learn that experience, the experience of eternity,

is only a beginning. It is not the bare experience which counts but its depth, its direction, its end. All men have a glimpse of eternity; or rather, a glimmering of eternity comes to all men. The human task is to develop that first glimmer.

In the view of Spinoza and those who think like him (notably, many of the master-minds of India), this task is shared by religion and philosophy, philosophy (perhaps) rather scrutinising the road, religion pressing on impatiently to the goal; or, religion gathering up the conclusions of philosophy, philosophy refining the intuitions of religion, but both of them seeing the one end with however varying intensity, both of them suggesting, or imposing, means. Both speak in terms of knowledge, knowledge which the seeker must acquire. What is peculiar to the type of thought represented by Spinoza is that it sees as the essential groundwork of that knowledge the systematic investigation of the physical world which we now call by the name of science. Religion is only the highest rung in the ascending ladder of mind.

For mind too has its reasons; and the reasons of the mind go deeper than the reasons of the heart. And mind, as we are told by Spinoza, is the better part of us; and the satisfaction of mind is the satisfaction of our highest being.

Yet curiosity is not our only instinct, and knowledge of the physical world is not our only channel of satisfaction. We should not ignore science. It is no enhancement of the glory of God to belittle the achievement of man. But we may legitimately rest assured that there are other spheres of aspiration and other instruments of achievement. Scientism too is not enough, and it does not exhaust the windows of our enlargement.

But enlarge ourselves we must. Creatures of time as we seemingly are, it is only through our grasp of eternity (whether *our* grasp on *eternity* or *eternity's* grasp on *us*) that we can escape from time. If we remain wholly within time, we are time's slaves, not, as we can and should be, time's masters. To those who master time, another world opens:

'Servants of time are slaves of slaves;
God's servant hath his freedom whole.
When every man his portion craves,
"God is my portion", saith my soul.'
(Halevi, trans. Salaman).

We may then follow the philosophers, we may follow the saints; more simply perhaps, and for us Jews more naturally, we may follow the Law and the Prophets, the Psalmists and the Rabbis. But whatever we do and however we strive, one thing is sure: the way is difficult, difficult to find, difficult to pursue.

And yet—it is Spinoza speaking—'it can nevertheless be found. It must indeed be difficult (I continue the words of his last grave warning) since it is so seldom discovered. For if salvation lay ready to hand and could be discovered without great labour, how could it come about that it should be neglected almost by all?'

'But every excellent thing is as difficult as it is rare.'